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Pakistan Studies



Assignment 3: Book Review

Pakistan: The Enigma of Political Development

By LawrenceZiring

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Introduction to the Author: Lawrence Ziring

Author's Writing Style

Ziring's writing is sharp, analytical, and deliberately provocative. He aims not simply to write down political events but to prompt discussion about the deeper reasons behind Pakistan's continuous political instability. As he notes in his preface, the book is not intended to be a detached, purely objective; instead, it offers a more personal interpretation that includes pointed and often critical observations.

His approach combines a chronological narrative with thematic analysis, allowing him to follow historical developments while exploring the structural issues underlying them. Ziring does not use unnecessary jargon and writes in a straightforward, accessible style, making his arguments easy for both students and general readers to engage with. His consistently critical tone underscores his intent to question established understandings of Pakistan's political trajectory.

Chapter Descriptions

Chapter 1: The Muslim Legacy in South Asia

According to Ziring, the political stance of Muslims in the subcontinent was heavily affected by memories of past empires, which influenced how they viewed themselves and their place during British rule. He puts forwards the progression of Muslim rule from the Delhi Sultanate to the Mughal Empire and explains how their decline under British authority produced insecurity and a sense of lost pride. These historical pressures resulted in emergence of the Muslim separatist movement. Ziring also notes that secular, Western educated leaders rather than religious ones drove the demand for Pakistan.

Chapter 2: Nationalism, Ideology, and the Islamic State

In this chapter, Ziring draws a clear line between nationalism, which he considers as an organic force that grows from the people, and ideology, which he views as a top- down tool in order to manage unity. He argues that Pakistan struggled to develop a truly shared national identity and that its leaders frequently relied on Islamic symbolism as an easy substitute for country's real ethnic diversity. In Ziring's view, this reliance on ideology weakened the emergence of genuine Pakistani nationalism and ultimately empowered ethnic divisions.

Chapter 3: The Creators and Early Managers of Pakistan

Ziring examines the individuals who were responsible for making the Pakistan movement and the early years of the state. He discusses the ideological contributions of the creators like Sir Syed Ahmed Khan along with Allama Muhammed Iqbal and enlightens how Jinnah's transformation from a champion of Hindu Muslim unity to the leader of a separate Muslim state. The chapter then highlights how political inexperience and institutional weakness after Jinnah's death allowed bureaucratic elites to dominate the newly established state.

Chapter 4: The Civil and Armed Bureaucrats

Ziring focuses on the rise of an all-powerful administrative establishment. He argues that the political groups failed early, allowing the bureaucracy and military as the only organized institutions to become capable of governing. The chapter gives special attention to General Ayub Khan, his disgust for civilian politicians, and the Basic Democracies system for centralizing the authority. Ziring also describes the eventual downfall of Ayub's government and the transfer of power to General Yahya Khan.

Chapter 5: Political Movements and Political Parties

This chapter investigates why Pakistan has struggled to create strong and democratic political parties. Ziring argues that movements organized around single causes, like the Muslim League's campaign for independence, rare transitions into effective

governing institutions. He compares this with the Pakistan People's Party (PPP), which started with a new and modern ideological platform but increasingly circled around Zulfikar Ali Bhutto's personal authority.

Chapter 6: The Submerged Nations: The Politics of Ethnicity and Tribalism

Ziring discusses the ethnic landscape of Pakistan, describing the Punjabis, Sindhis, Pathans in last the Balochis as distinct groups possessing their own political histories and concerns. He explains how the central government's attempts to enforce a uniform national identity often resulted in conflict. The chapter also explains the unequal power given to Punjabi dominance in state institutions contributed to ethnic tension .

Chapter 7: Incipient Constitutionalism

This chapter critiques Pakistan's history of constitutional attempts. Ziring argues that constitutional work repeatedly failed because the political leadership lacked democratic norms and because colonial administrative traditions continued to shape governance. He examines the 1956, 1962, and 1973 constitutions, affirming that each of them was undermined by authoritarian trends and unresolved debates over the meaning of an Islamic state.

Chapter 8: The Myth of Nation-Building

Ziring argues that Pakistan never was able to successfully build the foundational structures required for a stable and firm state. Instead, weak leadership and institutional imbalance produced a cycle in which the military interferes, attempts to rule, and eventually returns authority to unprepared civilians. He describes General Zia ul Haq's gaining of power, the execution of Bhutto and his prolonged rule under the banner of Islamization.

Chapter 9: The Foreign Policy Dimension

This chapter explains that Pakistan's foreign policy is shaped primarily by its security concerns regarding India. Ziring argues that Pakistan sought alliances with powerful external factors, such as the United States through SEATO and CENTO, as a means of compensating for its perceived military weakness. He then discusses the shift toward Middle Eastern partnerships after 1971 and the emergence of the "Afghanistan problem," which he viewed as a major threat even in 1979.

Chapter 10: The Future of Pakistan

In the concluding chapter, Ziring presents a bleak outlook of Pakistan's long-term prospects. He presents Pakistan as a weak political entity, vulnerable to both internal fragmentation and external pressures. He warns that evolving geopolitical challenges, could push Pakistan toward ideological transformations and further instability the challenges especially related to Iran and Afghanistan.

Chapter Summaries

Chapter 1: The Muslim Legacy in South Asia

This chapter provides the deep historical context for Pakistan's creation. Ziring argues the "essential legacy" is that South Asian Muslims are "descendants of conquerors," which makes them superior and fixes their relationship with non-Muslims. It explains the rise of Muslim power from the Sultanate of Delhi and the Mughals and its decline under the British, who favored the Hindu population. This loss of power and status led to the Muslim separatist movement. Ziring points out this movement was driven by Westernized leaders not the ulema (religious clerics), who strongly opposed partition. The chapter also explores the conflict between the Idea of a universal Muslim umma, seen in the Khalifat Movement.

Chapter 2: Nationalism, Ideology, and the Islamic State

This chapter first defines the key terms that harness Pakistan's politics. Ziring defines nationalism as a spontaneous force that grows from a people. In contrast, he defines ideology as a tool fabricated by an elite to unite a population that was otherwise divided and dispersed. He argues Pakistan failed to develop a true, unified nationalism. Instead, the Muslim League used the ideology of Islam to gain independence. After 1947, this same ideological approach was used by the central government to try and undermine the genuine cultural nationalisms of the Bengalis, Pathans and Baluchis, which only led to more conflict. The chapter ends by analyzing General Zia-ul-Haq's 1979 attempt to re-use Islamic ideology through Zakat and Ushr to unify the country where secular efforts had badly failed.

Chapter 3: The Creators and Early Managers of Pakistan

This chapter mentions the leaders who shaped the Pakistan movement and the new state. It begins with the three key figures who revived the Muslim community: Syed Ahmad Khan who pushed for modern education, Syed Amir Ali who pushed for political action and Allam Mohammad Iqbal the poet-philosopher who first provided the vision. It then elaborates Mohammad Ali Jinnah's career, tracing his shift from being a leading supporter of Hindu-Muslim cooperation in the Congress Party to the leader of the separatist movement after his political argument with Gandhi. The chapter's second half shows how, after Jinnah's death, the "early managers" like Khwaja Nazimuddin proved to be weak and unsuitable. This weakness allowed provincial conflicts especially the Bengali-Punjabi problem over representation and the powerful civil bureaucracy, led by figures like Ghulam Mohammad, to take control of the state, leading to the constant internal problems among politicians that destroyed the early democratic process.

Chapter 4: The Civil and Armed Bureaucrats

This chapter explains the rise of Pakistan's "administrative state." Ziring argues that after the politicians failed, the military bureaucratic elite were the only institution left that was stable and capable of ruling. The chapter focuses heavily on General Ayub Khan, who got power in the 1958 coup on invitation of Iskandar Mirza. He distrusted politicians, whom he saw as corrupt and anti-national, and built his system on a powerful alliance with the bureaucracy especially the elite Civil Service of Pakistan (CSP) and the armed forces. He created the Basic Democracies system to mobilize the rural masses and remove the urban political class. The chapter also provides details about the fall of Ayub Khan after the 1965 war and the student protests, leading directly to the transfer of power to another General Yahya Khan, who presided over the 1970 election and the previous civil war.

Chapter 5: Political Movements and Political Parties

This chapter analyzes why Pakistan has failed to build stable, democratic political parties. Ziring argues that political movements were good at achieving a goal like independence but are terrible at governing. The Muslim League is his primary example, it failed because it remained an exclusive movement for Muslims remained bound to particular small areas and could not transform itself into national party that could govern a diverse country. The chapter's second half analyzes the Pakistan People's Party (PPP). It began as a modern, ideological party with a socialist platform, but it quickly became a personal vehicle for its charismatic leader, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto. Bhutto ruled through his own personality rather than the party, and ultimately turned his government into a system centered entirely on his own personality.

Chapter 6: The Submerged Nations: The Politics of Ethnicity and Tribalism

This chapter explains the "many nations" inside Pakistan that the central government tried to suppress which resulted in massive instability. It covers the four major groups in West Pakistan. The Punjabis as the largest, most developed and most influential group, and their dominance of the military and bureaucracy creates tensions in the other provinces. The Sindhis have a feudal (wadera) system and felt pushed back by both the Punjabi dominated government and the muhajir (refugee) community that controlled Karachi's economy. The Pathans of the NWFP were a proud, tribal society with a long history of continued central rule, which fueled the "Pakhtunistan" separatist movement supported by Afghanistan. The Baluchis are the least populated and tribal area, their forced merger into Pakistan and the subsequent exploitation of their natural resources for example the Sui gas led to repeated, violent also armed revolts.

Chapter 7: Incipient Constitutionalism

This chapter argues that constitutional government in Pakistan has been an empty show rather than a substance. Ziring highlights the country's four constitutional periods. The first (1947-1956) was based on the old Government of India Act which was destroyed when Governor-General Ghulam Mohammad dissolved the Constituent Assembly on 24 October 1954 validated by citing the doctrine of necessity. The 1956 Constitution was a weak parliamentary system that was ignored by the leaders

and ended in 1958. The 1962 Constitution was written by Ayub Khan to legalize his presidential system which was controlled by bureaucrats and the military. The 1973 Constitution was Bhutto's attempt to create an all-powerful Prime Minister's office, but he too ruled above it. Ziring concludes that constitutionalism has repeatedly failed because it conflicts with the colonial, authoritarian tradition and unresolved debates over the precise definition and function of an Islamic state.

Chapter 8: The Myth of Nation-Building

This chapter presents the book's central thesis. Ziring states that nation-building in Pakistan is a myth because the country has failed at the more basic task of state-building. The political leaders were inexperienced and were not prepared for governing and were quickly pushed aside by the only stable institutions: the bureaucracy and the military this in return created a continuous cycle of coups. The military is embarrassed by its political role and keeps trying to give power back to civilians, which creates permanent instability. The chapter details the 1977 coup by General Zia-ul-Haq, who undermined the Bhutto. It covers Bhutto's trial and execution and Zia's consolidation of power, not as a permanent dictator, but as a temporary leader trying to build a new Islamic system before conducting new elections which he repeatedly postponed.

Chapter 9: The Foreign Policy Dimension

This chapter explains that Pakistan's foreign policy has been consistently effected by one single factor defensive posture against the threat from India. This national obsession has shaped every decision. It forced Pakistan to seek security from outside powers, leading it to join US led alliances like SEATO and CENTO in the 1950s simply to get military aid. This relationship worsen after the US supplied arms to India in 1962 and imposed an arms ban on Pakistan during the 1965 war. After the 1971 war and the loss of East Pakistan, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto re-prepared the country's policy away from South Asia and towards the Middle East seeking financial support from oil rich Arab states. The chapter also details the Afghanistan Problem, including the Pakhtunistan issue and the 1978 Marxist coup, which Ziring correctly identified as a major new threat to Pakistan's security as per in 1979.

Chapter 10: The Future of Pakistan

In this concluding chapter, Ziring provides a very pessimistic outlook on Pakistan's survival. He states that Pakistan is a fragile and unstable country that never truly became a nation in its true meaning. He argues the entire process of creating the country is at risk of complete collapse due to its unresolved internal ethnic divisions and external threats. The collapse of the Shah in neighboring Iran and the Soviet-backed coup in Afghanistan left Pakistan extremely exposed and isolated. General Zia's attempt to build a support of Muslim nations is seen as a desperate attempt to find a new source of legitimacy. Ziring concludes that these pressures are destroying the remaining connections to the West and that a Marxist-socialist framework may end its existence as a sovereign state.

Comprehensive Analysis: Our Opinion and Overview

Lawrence Ziring's work serves as a detailed analysis of the structural flaws that have hindered Pakistan since its creation. His central thesis revolves around the enigma of a state that was founded on democratic. Ziring argues that this is not an accident but a result of historical shaping. He suggests that the Muslims of South Asia view themselves through the lens of their historical legacy as conquerors of the Mughals and earlier Islamic dynasties rather than as a minority group seeking accommodation. This psychological makeup created a political culture that struggles with the requirement for democracy.

The book persuasively argues that the failure of political parties in the early years created a vacuum that the civil and military bureaucracies were all too willing to fill that vacuum created due to unprepared politicians. Ziring claims that these Guardians considered themselves as the only true patriots capable of holding the broken country together. He examines how they deliberately weakened the political system, convinced that the disorder of parliamentary democracy posed a danger to national security.

Strengths of the Book

Book's analytical strength is solid, especially in how clearly it defines the core strategic realities:

- Thematic over Chronological: A key strength of the book lies in its thematic rather than chronological organization. Instead of following a basic timeline, Ziring structures the analysis around themes such as the military's role, the illusion of constitutionalism, and the politics of ethnicity. This approach helps readers see that the military coups were not isolated events but part of a recurring pattern in which the bureaucratic state repeatedly asserts dominance over the political state.
- Personalized Insight: The author admits to a personalized approach, using his decades of experience and direct contact with Pakistan's leadership to inform the readers about his own views. This moves the book beyond dry theory and gives it a sense and reality. He offers a nuanced portrayal of leaders like Ayub Khan, presenting them not merely as dictators but as figures who sincerely believed they were rescuing the country from political instability.
- Predictive Value regarding Religion: Ziring offers a strong analysis of how Islam is used politically. He points that secular experiments failed to unify the country, leaders turned to Islamic ideology not necessarily out of piety, but as a political survival strategy to legitimize their rule when other methods failed.

Gaps and Weaknesses

While powerful, the work contains limitations present in its context:

- ☐ **Historical Cutoff:** The most obvious gap is that the book was published in 1980. While Ziring accurately identifies the rising threat of the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan and the consolidation of General Zia-ul-Haq's power, he could not foresee the long-term effect that the Afghan war would bring to Pakistani society.
- ☐ **Pessimistic Determinism:** The tone of the book is often bleak. Ziring tends to view Pakistan's history as a tragedy of errors, heavily implying that the country is trapped in a cycle it cannot escape. This deterministic view sometimes overlooks the resilience of the Pakistani people and the civil society that has survived despite repeated military interventions.

Points of Agreement and Disagreement

I. Agreement:

- ☐ **Myth of Nation-Building:** The review matches with the author's main argument that nation-building in Pakistan has effectively been a myth. **State vs. Nation:** There is strong agreement with the idea that Pakistan is a state but not yet a unified nation. This is primarily due to the central government's historical failure to unite ethnic minorities in Baluchistan, Sindh, and the Frontier regions. **Administrative Control:** The author accurately observes that the state has consistently relied on administration rather than genuine political integration to manage these groups.

II. Disagreement:

- ☐ **Oversimplification of Legacy:** One can disagree with the author that he blames the historical Muslim legacy for the absence of democracy. Attributing contemporary political failures largely to a "conqueror mindset" risks oversimplification of the far more complex economic and geopolitical challenges the new state faced. **Grassroots Aspirations:** Although the book's criticism of early landlords and politicians is largely valid, it may understate the genuine democratic aspirations that existed at the grassroots level. One could argue that these aspirations were indeed present, but were consistently suppressed by the state apparatus rather than absent altogether.

Conclusion

To conclude, Lawrence Ziring's *Pakistan: The Enigma of Political Development* remains an important text for anyone seeking to understand the deep roots of Pakistan's political instability. Although the book was published in 1980 and therefore doesn't capture the profound changes brought by the post-Soviet Afghan war, its core insights still feel strikingly relevant today.

Ziring doesn't just re-tell history, he digs into the deeper structural and psychological tensions that were present. He highlights how, from the very start, the state was shaped by a built-in struggle between old authoritarian habits and genuine democratic hopes.

Ultimately, the book's greatest contribution is its realism. It strips away the myths of nation building to reveal a state struggling to present itself against internal divisions and external security issues. For students of political science, this work is not just a history lesson; it is a guide to the continuous patterns of civil military power imbalance and institutional failure that continue to define Pakistan's political landscape today. It makes a convincing statement that unless the core identity crisis and power imbalances are finally addressed mentioned by Ziring, the puzzle of the country's political evolution will remain unresolved.

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